

Tradition and Innovation

With mounting use of composites and the increasing dominance of the Rotax 912 engine (which had been launched in 1989), the 1990s saw the emergence of small kitplanes, which totally outperformed the traditional general aviation two-seater. The introduction of the Global Positioning System (GPS) brought a radical change to aircraft communication and navigation capabilities.



△ Commander 114B 1992

Origin USA

Engine 260 hp Lycoming IO-540
air-cooled flat-6

Top speed 165 mph (266 km/h)

Descended from the Rockwell 112, the Commander 114B is a sleek and powerful four-seat retractable tourer. The original Commander was allegedly designed by engineers who also worked on the Space Shuttle. Although the type never sold as well as its main competitor, the Beechcraft Bonanza, it has a loyal following.



△ Robin DR-400-180 Regent 1992

Origin France

Engine 180 hp Lycoming O-360
air-cooled flat-4

Top speed 125 mph (201 km/h)

The installation of a more powerful engine and other improvements ensured that the DR-400 continued to sell well, several decades after it first flew. Probably the most obvious difference from earlier models is that the Regent has an extra row of windows.



△ Sky Arrow 650 TC 1992

Origin Italy

Engine 100 hp Rotax 912S
liquid-cooled flat-4

Top speed 116 mph (186 km/h)

This unusual Italian aircraft is a strut-braced high-wing design with tandem seats, and is powered by a Rotax 912 arranged in the "pusher" configuration. It offers an exceptional field-of-view from its fighterlike canopy.



△ Maule MXT-7-160 Star Rocket 1993

Origin USA

Engine 10 hp Lycoming O-320
air-cooled flat-4

Top speed 120 mph (193 km/h)

The Star Rocket is unusual for a bushplane in that it has a tricycle undercarriage. It possesses the same fine short takeoff and landing (STOL) characteristics as all Maule airplanes.



△ Europa XS 1994

Origin UK

Engine 100 hp Rotax 912S liquid-cooled flat-4

Top speed 145 mph (233 km/h)

Capable of very impressive performance on engines as small as 80 hp, the Europa XS evolved from the Europa Classic. Available with a monowheel or tricycle undercarriage, it is probably the most successful British kitplane.



△ Maule M-7-235C Orion 1997

Origin USA

Engine 235 hp Lycoming IO-540
air-cooled flat-6

Top speed 164 mph (264 km/h)

Famed for their sparkling short takeoff and landing characteristics, the Maule series make excellent bushplanes. Unlike earlier Maules, which used an Oleo-type undercarriage, the Orion uses a sprung aluminum arrangement, unless it is mounted on floats, such as the example shown.

